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Culture (OWC): [Ila \(FQ06\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: No Date

Coverage Date: 1902-1947

Place Coverage: South-Central Zambia (Ila)

Section Title(S)

OTHER SOCIAL GROUPS • POLITICAL ORGANIZATION • SLAVERY

Any man in the owner's community could have relatively free sexual access to unmarried slave women.

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Slavery

In no case could a slave redeem himself or herself so as to be free. But a slave who considered himself to be ill-treated beyond endurance could transfer himself to another owner by throwing ash upon him. This was one of the *budithazi*^{28A} offences for which a man could be held to ransom for cattle, or enslaved. By committing such an offence a slave could oblige his own master to pay ransom for him; this was a recognized device for acquiring a new master in place of an uncongenial one.

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Slavery

OTHER SOCIAL GROUPS

The Ila have a practice of making covenants of friendship with one another, which vary in duration and purpose. Blood brotherhood, entered into at a solemn ceremony of mutual skin incision and consumption of each other's blood (*mulongo wa maninga*), is the most binding of these.²⁹ Age-sets are also recognized, and are formed of all men and all women born in the same year, and all who have been through initiation ceremonies in the same year. Such sets of people are called *misela* (sing. *musela*). Membership is expressed in a joking relationship and by the obligation of mutual aid.³⁰

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Age Stratification

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Friendships

POLITICAL ORGANIZATION

The Ila have never had any centralized political organization or a paramount chief over all petty chiefs. The country was divided into about 80 communes (*cishi*) each under its own independent chief. A *cishi* consisted of one large and several smaller villages, or of a number of villages more or less equal in size. Some communes had no more than 100 members, while others had about 3,000, the largest being Kasenga.³¹

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Tribe And Nation

The territorial boundaries between *cishi* were strictly demarcated and were treated with ritual respect. Moving or altering a neighbour's border marks sometimes led to an outbreak of warfare between the two communities. Trespass on another community's land was punished. In order to hunt or fish a stranger had first to seek permission and then to acknowledge the privilege granted him with a portion of the gains (*impaizo*).³²

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Tribe And Nation

Each commune was "in a constant state of feud" with others³³ and thus always potentially at war. Intermarriage between communes could, however, take place, so that people in different communes were connected by individual ties of kinship.³⁴

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Tribe And Nation

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Inter-Community
Relations

^{28A} *Budithazi* offences, for which a man could be held to ransom, included calling a person by a wrong name, claiming false relationship, bearing false witness, making a sacrifice to the ancestor spirits of another person, and many other offences relating to bodily elimination, cleanliness, and social etiquette. The precise significance of the custom is not clear (Smith and Dale, 1920, I, pp. 370–4).

²⁹ Ibid., p. 308.

³⁰ Ibid., pp. 309–10.

³¹ Ibid., pp. 298–9.

³² Ibid., pp. 299, 387, 388.

³³ Gluckman, 1949, p. 90.

³⁴ Smith and Dale, 1920, I, p. 283.

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